



ULAB

UNIVERSITY OF LIBERAL ARTS
BANGLADESH

Department of Media Studies and Journalism

Course: Data Journalism

Course Code: MSJ3253

Section: 01

Fall 2025

Topic:
Final Project

Submitted to:

Dewan Shahnoor Alam Sourav

Lecturer

Department of Media Studies and Journalism
University of Liberal Arts Bangladesh (ULAB)

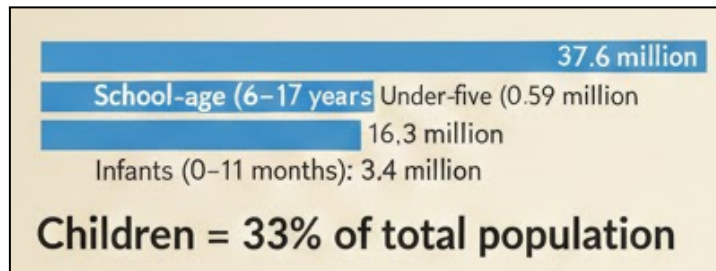
Submitted By:

Name	ID
Samiul Khan Odoy	191012035
Dean Mohammad Sabbir	212012031
Y easir arafat	213012001
Md. Abid Rahman	221012014

Bangladesh's Children at Risk: Growing Up Vulnerable

Staff Correspondent:

Bangladesh is widely recognized as a development success story, often cited for its progress in poverty reduction, immunization coverage, and access to primary education. However, when the situation of children is examined closely through data, a more complex and troubling picture emerges. With a total population of nearly 170 million, Bangladesh is home to approximately 56.9 million children under the age of 18, representing one-third of the population. This demographic reality means that national progress and national failure are both most clearly reflected in the lives of children. While headline indicators suggest improvement, deeper analysis reveals that millions of children remain exposed to overlapping risks related to identity, education, health, protection, and climate vulnerability.



One in Three in Bangladesh Is a Child; Nearly Half Without Birth Certificate:

One of the earliest and most critical points of exclusion begins at birth. Despite years of digital governance reforms, 44% of children under the age of five do not have their births registered. Lack of birth registration is not a technical issue; it directly affects access to education, health services, social protection schemes, and legal safeguards against child marriage and child labour. Child rights researchers in Bangladesh note that unregistered children are more likely to drop out of school, enter informal labour, or become victims of early marriage, particularly in rural and climate-affected regions. In practice, invisibility at birth often translates into long-term institutional neglect.

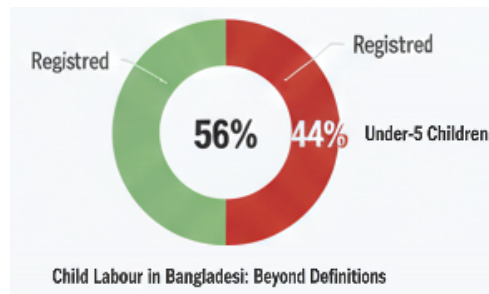


Photo: Street Child. Credit: Unicef

Street Children Face Multiple Forms of Abuse

The situation becomes even more severe for children living and working on the streets. According to the 2022 UNICEF and Bangladesh Bureau of Statistics survey on street children, more than 30% of

these children sleep in open public spaces such as streets, terminals, and parks without access to basic amenities. Nearly 72% cannot read or write, reflecting complete exclusion from formal education. Violence is a daily reality, with over 82% reporting abuse or harassment by pedestrians and nearly half experiencing violence at their workplace. Social workers working in Dhaka's informal settlements argue that street-connected children exist outside all formal systems of protection, making them effectively invisible in policy planning despite their growing numbers.

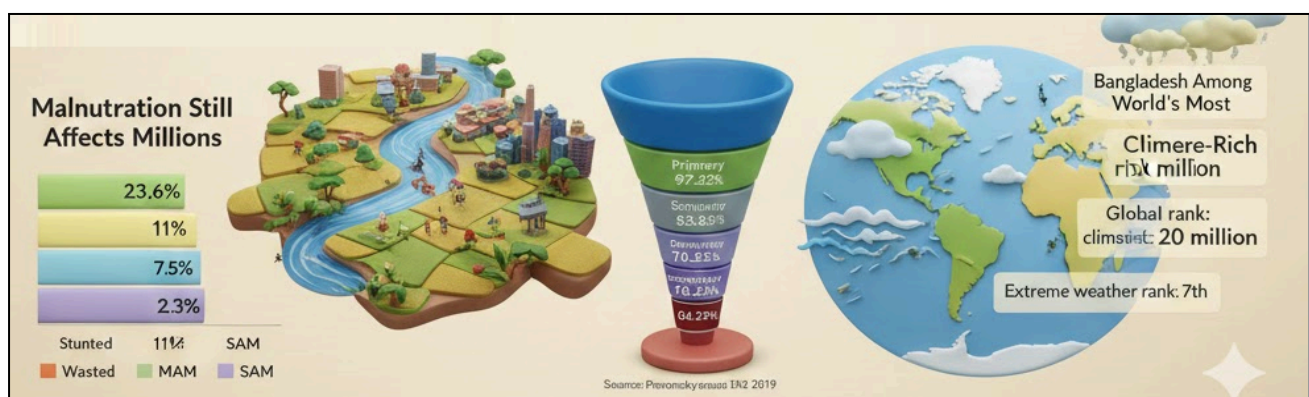
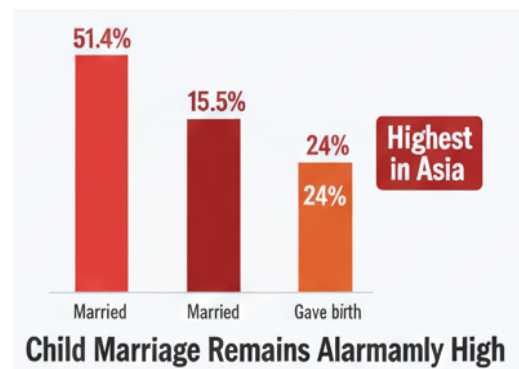


Child Labour: The Reality Behind the Numbers

Economic pressure further pushes many children into labour. Data from the Multiple Indicator Cluster Survey shows that 11.3% of children aged 5 to 17 are engaged in child labour, hazardous work, or both. 8% are involved specifically in hazardous occupations that pose serious risks to physical and mental health. When this data is examined alongside education statistics, a clear pattern emerges: secondary school dropout rates exceed 35%, and many children who leave school at this stage enter informal labour markets. Rising inflation, household debt, and climate-related displacement are increasingly forcing families to prioritize short-term survival over long-term education.

Child Marriage in Bangladesh Still Shockingly High

Child marriage remains one of the most persistent and damaging forms of child rights violations in Bangladesh. More than 50% of women aged 20 to 24 were married before the age of 18, and over 15% were married before the age of 15. Nearly 25% gave birth before turning 18. While child marriage is often framed as a cultural issue, data and expert analysis show strong links to poverty, low levels of female education, and climate vulnerability. Gender policy analysts working in disaster-prone regions note that early marriage rates tend to rise after floods and cyclones, suggesting that families use marriage as a coping strategy during crises rather than as a purely traditional practice.



Climate Hazards Threaten Millions of Bangladeshi Children

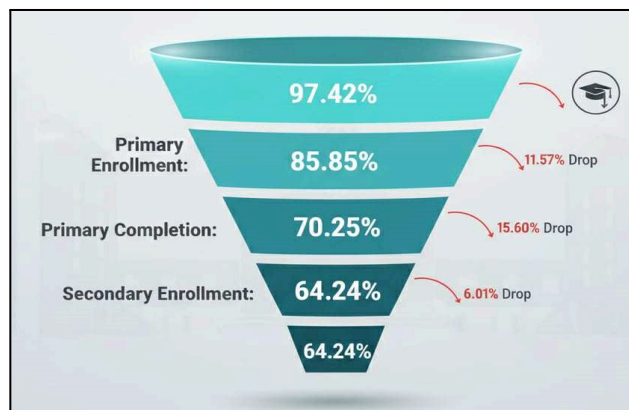
Climate change has emerged as a powerful force intensifying existing vulnerabilities. Approximately 20 million children in Bangladesh are seriously exposed to climate hazards such as floods, cyclones, river erosion, heatwaves, and salinity intrusion. Bangladesh ranks among the countries most affected by extreme weather events and is classified as one of the highest-risk nations for children facing climate impacts. Climate shocks disrupt schooling, worsen food insecurity, and increase the likelihood of child labour and early marriage. Increasingly, children are becoming climate migrants, forced to move with their families before reaching adulthood, often losing access to education and healthcare in the process.

Nutrition Status of Under-Five Children

Health indicators present a mixed picture. Immunization coverage is relatively strong, with over 93% of children receiving key vaccines by their first birthday. However, nutrition data reveals persistent challenges. Nearly 24% of children under five are stunted, and 11% are wasted, indicating chronic and acute malnutrition. Only 28.7% of children aged 6 to 23 months receive a minimum acceptable diet. Public health experts point out that this contradiction reflects not failures in vaccination programs but deeper problems related to food insecurity, maternal nutrition, poverty, and climate stress.

Children Drop Out Before Completing School

Education outcomes further highlight systemic gaps. While primary school net enrolment exceeds 97%, completion rates decline sharply at higher levels. Only about 64% of students complete secondary education, and dropout rates remain high. Children with disabilities face even greater barriers, with only 40% enrolled in formal education. Education specialists argue that while access to schooling has improved on paper, meaningful inclusion and retention have not kept pace, particularly for marginalized children.



Rana Flowers, UNICEF representative in Bangladesh, said: *"A clear and achievable path for change for children has already been identified, which will contribute to human resource development. To build a stronger Bangladesh in the future, we need to pinpoint where children are being left behind. The reduction in child marriage and child mortality shows that progress is possible, but crises like lead contamination and child labour continue to prevent millions of children from reaching their full potential. When every child's right to survive, develop, and learn is respected, the benefits can be measured through a more economically resilient Bangladesh."*

Millions of children continue to face overlapping vulnerabilities that threaten their survival, growth, and future opportunities. From lack of birth registration and exclusion from education to child labour, early marriage, and climate-related displacement, the challenges are complex and interconnected. Addressing these issues requires targeted interventions, robust social protection systems, and sustained commitment from both the government and civil society. Ensuring that every child is seen, protected, and empowered is not only a moral imperative but also a crucial investment in Bangladesh's long-term development and resilience. Without urgent and coordinated action, a significant portion of the country's next generation risks being left behind.

Taken together, the data reveals that children in Bangladesh are not failing; rather, they are navigating systems that consistently fail to address intersecting risks. A child without birth registration is more likely to leave school early, a child affected by climate displacement is more likely to enter labour or early marriage, and a malnourished child is less likely to learn effectively even when enrolled in school. Development indicators may continue to improve, but inequality persists quietly beneath national averages.

Note:

This data story is based on the research report by **UNICEF Bangladesh**. All data and information have been analyzed and interpreted using AI tools. This report was developed using AI-assisted tools to support data organization, narrative structuring, and analytical synthesis. All interpretations, contextual analysis, and editorial decisions were made by the author, with data drawn from UNICEF Bangladesh and nationally recognized surveys. The findings underscore the urgent need for integrated, child-centred policies that address not just individual indicators but the complex realities shaping children's lives in Bangladesh.

Source: [UNICEF Bangladesh – Situation of Children in Bangladesh](#)

Disclaimer:

All infographics in this story have been generated using **Gemini**. The author is responsible for all analysis, narrative, and journalistic interpretation.